



e and!

feminine voices

Mary Cassatt

Letter

from the Editor



Welcome to the first issue of *egad!*, a magazine for readers, writers, and my closest friends. *egad!* began as a graduate project, but somewhere between the layouts, typography, and endless tweaking, it became something much more personal. I wanted to create the kind of publication I love stumbling across in bookstores and libraries—a magazine made by readers, for readers. One that values genuine curiosity over clicks, thoughtful essays that tap into your friends’ inner worlds, and beautiful design as much as beautiful writing.

For years, writing has been my career. Except somewhere along the way, writing stopped feeling like a passion. Even reading, my favorite hobby, got me anxious. I sat there analyzing the author’s diction, their sentence structure, their plotting and resolutions. I’d feel momentarily inspired, word-vomit into a journal, and scribble out sentences before the ink had a chance to dry. Nothing was good enough, and I refused to share my work with anyone beyond an assignment. I turned a pastime into ammunition.

As my M.A. thesis approached, I asked myself: *What made me fall in love with words in the first place?*

The answer wasn’t buried in copywriting revenue or a perfect GPA. It was much simpler. It was the newspaper I made as a kid called *Family Times*, complete with movie reviews and coverage of my brother’s baseball games. It was spending hours writing silly stories to swap with friends for no other reason than celebrating art we’d created. It was turning final papers into zines because physical media made my work feel alive.

Community, as cheesy as that sounds, is the answer. It’s creating because I *want* to. I write to be read. I read to discuss what I learned with friends. We grow closer with each recommendation, each messy draft, each book review. Art bonds us in inexplicable ways, and I can’t stifle myself any longer, or I threaten to squash the bonds I’ve built on foundations of passion, whimsy, vulnerability, and a love of words.

This magazine is my attempt to rediscover that love. Our inaugural theme, “Feminine Voices,” celebrates literature shaped by women that’s been read, reviewed, and written by my friends. Inside you’ll find book reviews and essays that explore the many ways stories shape our understanding of ourselves and each other. My hope is that you’ll discover a new favorite book, reconsider an old one, or simply enjoy spending time with people who love stories as much as you do.

Above all, I hope this issue reminds you—as it has reminded me—that your passions are supposed to be shared. Sometimes the greatest joy doesn’t come from doing what you love, but inviting others to join you.

Happy reading,

Darby Tanner

egad!

The Feminine Voices Issue

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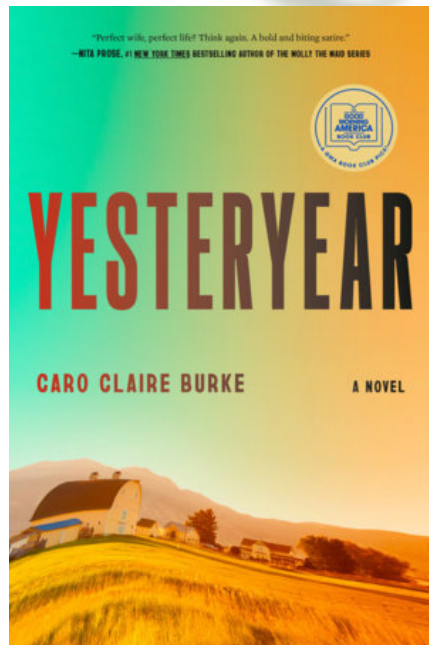
Cover: *Woman With a Red Zinnia (Revery)*, 1891, Mary Cassatt, Chester Dale Collection, National Gallery

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Rave reviews

book reviews
from avid readers

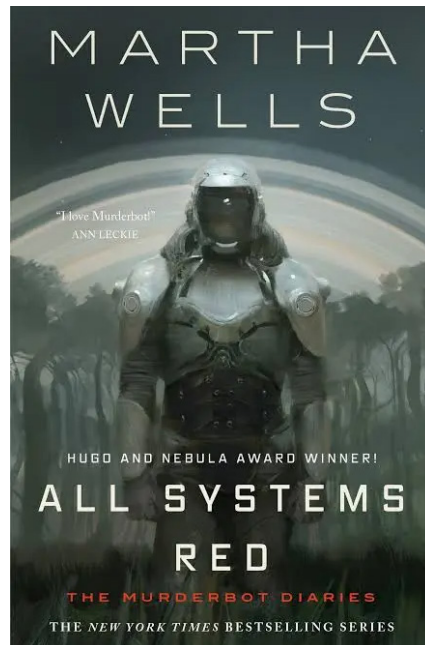
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YESTERYEAR

CARO CLAIRE BURKE

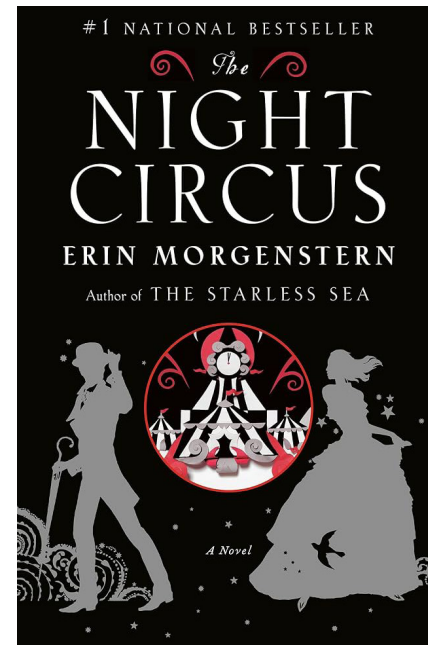
“Natalie Heller Mills was a perfect rancher’s wife, mother, homemaker, and Christian . . . at least on social media. Offline, her children were being raised by nannies, she was raising her husband, and her life was being perfectly curated by a producer. That is until one day when she wakes up in 1855 and must actually live the life she’s been selling to millions. And it turns out Natalie isn’t as perfect at the job as she thought. *Yesteryear* is a biting satire with thriller elements that keep you flying through the short chapters. Natalie is a classic unlikeable and unreliable narrator. You’ll hate her so much that you’ll be itching to see the next insane, self-absorbed, and delusional thing she’ll say. And she won’t disappoint. A valid critique of the novel is that the characters feel like caricatures—but that’s the point. Caro Claire Burke has grasped society by the throat and forced it to reckon with the reality of the ‘tradwife’ image that has swept social media.”— *Katy Burch*



ALL SYSTEMS RED

MARTHA WELLS

“I picked up *All Systems Red* looking for a quick vacation read, and it delivered a little more than I expected. Martha Wells introduces us to a security android who’s hacked his own governing system, but he would rather binge soap operas than deal with humans. His deadpan internal commentary on humans’ contradictions had me laughing out loud more than once. Humor and the plot’s intrigue really carry the book. What surprised me is how much Wells packs into so few pages. The plot moves fast and the read is breezy, but the worldbuilding is surprisingly fleshed out. There’s clearly a much bigger universe here, and the somewhat open-ended conclusion invites you to continue with the series. It’s rare for a novella to feel both effortless and substantial, but this one pulls it off. Great pick if you want sharp humor, a fast read, and a protagonist who’d rather not be your friend but ends up being everyone’s favorite anyway.”— *Chris E.*

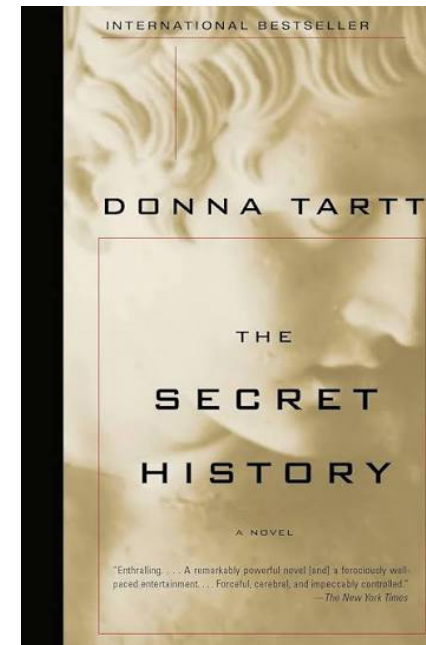


THE NIGHT CIRCUS

ERIN MORGENSTERN

“*The Night Circus* offers romance, magic, and mystique. Two mentors select protégés to compete; however, the only information provided is the venue in which they will compete, Le Cirque des Rêves. The competitors create experiences within the night circus with no guidance on how to ‘win.’ Would you like to play a game where you don’t know the rules? *You* might as well be playing the game, too. The drama surrounding the key romance will remind readers of the damning love between Romeo and Juliet. The clock is ticking, the rivalry is heating up, and by the time all is revealed, it may be too late for our lovers to save what matters most. Morgenstern’s detail brings magic to life and will leave readers questioning if this is truly her debut. This is a book that I would recommend reading twice: the first time to experience the story, the second time to appreciate it.”

— *J. DeWitt*

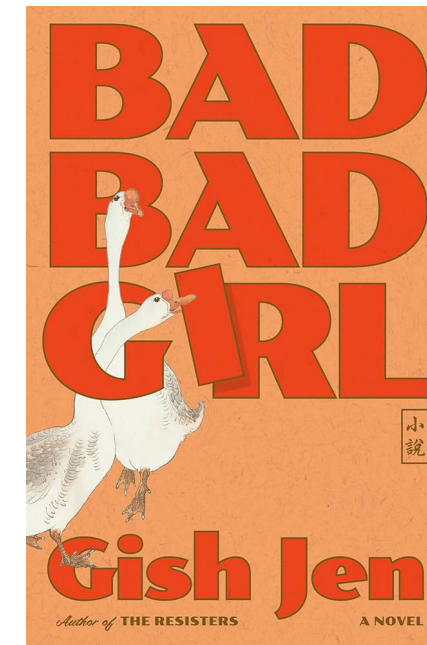


THE SECRET HISTORY

DONNA TARTT

“*The Secret History* is one of the first books to make me want to annotate. I ran out of several tab colors and had to resort to underlining, which allowed me to grow a fondness for letting my books look less pristine. The small distinctions between characters, the allowance of inference in their actions, and missed conversations and secrets made the reading experience so incredibly rich I didn’t want to put it down. Tartt creates intoxicatingly vivid imagery with beautiful flowing prose that creates a haunting dark academia vibe. I loved exploring her character work between six elite college students (minus our protagonist, Robert) studying Greek and covering up murders. She also takes a unique twist on the murder mystery by revealing the identity of the second victim within the first sentence of the story, allowing the tension to rise around the manner in which the character meets their end instead of who it may be, which I found thrilling.”

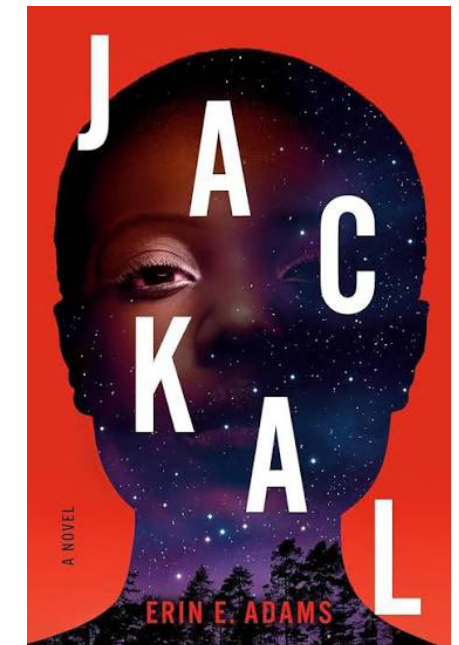
— *Joan Knox*



BAD BAD GIRL

GISH JEN

“Jen expertly targets the odd sensation of longing for a specific, more idyllic relationship a child could wish to experience with their parent with a raw vulnerability that has really sat with me in the several months since finishing the novel. I fell in love with the medium in which Jen chose to tell this story. It begins as a work of fiction following Jen’s mother while she is a child living in Shanghai during Japanese occupation and follows the paths she took after immigrating to the US in pursuit of her PhD and as she starts their family. The transition follows the author’s memoir of navigating the fraught relationship shared with her mother in relation to generational cycles of abuse through the lens of traditional Chinese culture and values. Jen’s attention to detail and concise prose builds a gorgeously crafted story that considers her upbringing with such warmth and understanding and acceptance that it brought tears to my eyes.”— *Joan Knox*



JACKAL

ERIN E. ADAMS

“Liz Rocher has reluctantly returned to her small, white Pennsylvania town for her best friend’s wedding. But at the reception, the bride’s daughter goes missing. *Jackal* had me hooked from the beginning. It’s a mix of horror and magical realism that twists your mind in ways you’d never expect. The suspense was well done with social commentary on the intersection of racism and class intricately woven throughout. However, concrete details of pivotal scenes weren’t entirely fleshed out. This was forgivable because of the genre. The biggest problem was the reveal of the accomplice. The author made it possible for any of the main male suspects to be the killer, and it felt like she chose one at random at the end. This could’ve been commentary on how it is ‘all men’ who are dangerous; instead, the reveal fell flat because we weren’t provided with additional revelations. It’s still a wholly original premise that led to an engaging and haunting horror.”— *Katy Burch*



Taylor Cannon, 2026

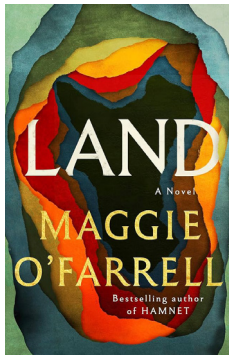


BLOOD OVER BRIGHT HAVEN

M.L. WANG

“*Blood Over Bright Haven* follows the first woman to ever be accepted into the High Magistracy as a highmage. Sciona is highly clever, driven by not only her ego but also the want of equal opportunity for the women around her. Magic is the energy source of the city, and Wang creates a really interesting magic system that works like computer code that was so fun to explore as the characters tested its boundaries. Characters are not stagnant and instead grow and change over time, which is something I love in my stories. Sciona is forced to work with Thomil, a man considered to be lesser-than due to his nomadic lifestyle, and must forgo her prejudices to find and accept the truth even as it unravels her own version of reality. She is a gorgeously flawed and strong narrator, and I absolutely adored watching her growth throughout the novel.”

– *Joan Knox*

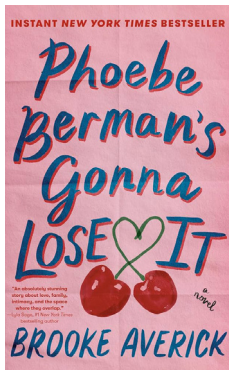


LAND

MAGGIE O'FARRELL

“This is the story of a land, and its power—the way it connects us all through time and space. In particular, this story focuses on a specific plot of land in Ireland and its effect on the family who reside upon it. We have Tomás, the father and leader of their group, and Phina, the mother with a hidden backstory. Their children: intelligent Liam, strong willed Enda, nurturing Rose, and wise Eugene. Set a decade after the Grame Famine, the family’s tale weaves together with history in a way that speaks deeply to the soul. I was greatly moved.”

– *Tori Craun*



PHOEBE BERMAN'S GONNA LOSE IT

BROOKE AVERICK

“I laughed, I cried, and most importantly: I felt seen. From the physical manifestations of anxiety at the thought of dating, to being an inexperienced 30 year old, to having conflicted feelings over a guy friend, Phoebe feels real and relatable. Phoebe is a bit of a mess, but in the most heartfelt and honest way. She makes you root for her, support her, and love her through her faults. While she grows a lot over the course of this book, she stays true to her inner self. As for the writing, it is witty and has a great flow. Each character comes to life easily, and they feel believable. I definitely recommend this one to romcom and romance lovers! ”

– *Tori Craun*



THE WILL TO CHANGE

BELL HOOKS

“If I could make one book required reading for every adult, it might be *The Will to Change*. bell hooks unpacks how patriarchy harms us all: it teaches men to suppress their emotions, disconnect from themselves, and carry those wounds into every relationship they have. It’s not a book about blaming men; it’s about understanding the system we’ve all been raised in and imagining something better. Regardless of gender, sexual orientation, or relationship status, there’s something here that will change the way you think about love, vulnerability, and the people you’ve engaged in romantic relationships with. Few books have shifted my perspective as much as this one.”

– *Elise Rikard*

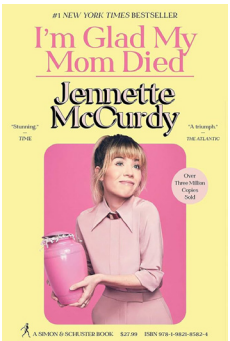


YELLOWFACE

R.F. KUANG

“Imagine being such a mediocre white woman that your solution to writer’s block is stealing your dead Asian friend’s manuscript—literally from the crime scene. That’s the premise of *Yellowface*, and R.F. Kuang uses it to brilliantly dissect the publishing industry, social media discourse, performative allyship, and the stories we tell ourselves to justify our own bad behavior. June is an infuriating narrator because she genuinely believes she’s the victim, even while profiting from Athena’s work and identity. It’s clever, stressful, impossible to put down, and one of the smartest commentaries on race, publishing, and internet culture I’ve ever read.”

– *Elise Rikard*

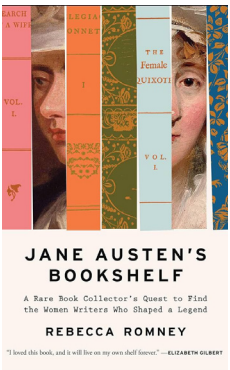


I'M GLAD MY MOM DIED

JENNETTE MCCURDY

“Jennette McCurdy’s memoir deserves every bit of praise it’s received—not just because of the story but because she’s an incredible writer. Even if you didn’t grow up in Hollywood, chances are you’ll recognize pieces of yourself somewhere in these pages. She writes vulnerably about eating disorders, impossible expectations, emotionally immature parents, manipulation, gaslighting, and slowly realizing that the adults who were supposed to protect you sometimes caused the deepest wounds. It’s heartbreaking, unexpectedly funny, and ultimately hopeful. I would read literally anything Jennette McCurdy writes because of her beautifully honest prose.”

– *Elise Rikard*

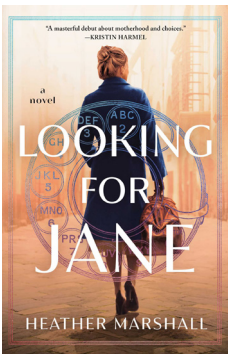


JANE AUSTEN'S BOOKSHELF: A Rare Book Collector's Quest to Find the Women Writers Who Shaped a Legend

REBECCA ROMNEY

“If you’re craving more Austen in your life, why not raid her bookshelf? Rare book collector Rebecca Romney (unintentionally?) wrote the ultimate book of recommendations for Austen lovers. She explores the life, works, and reputations of women writers Austen read and admired (Frances Burney, Ann Radcliffe, Charlotte Lennox, etc.) as well as other contemporaries she read but didn’t admire as much (ahem, Hannah More). Read by the author, the audiobook was the perfect companion on my daily commute. My only regret was that I couldn’t write down all of the book titles while I was driving!”

– *Darby Tanner*



LOOKING FOR JANE

HEATHER MARSHALL

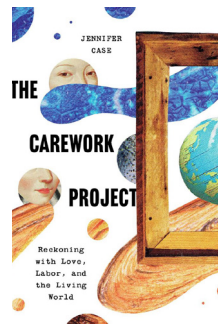
“This book contains themes of reproductive rights, abortion, maternity homes, and forced adoption. It resonates so deeply as both a historical and modern day tale—politically, socially, and systemically. It was written incredibly well, and you can tell a lot of care was put into bringing a realistic feeling to the characters. They are rich, lively, individualized, and have souls. This was a read that flowed well and tugged at the reader’s heartstrings. I particularly enjoyed the author’s presentation of her research at the end, as I was not very familiar with this particular part of Canada’s history. Recommended for mature readers who are into historical fiction or are interested in Canadian history.”

– *Tori Craun*

Add to tbr

The Carework Project:

RECKONING WITH LOVE, LABOR, AND THE LIVING



WORLD
BY JENNIFER CASE: Part memoir and part cultural reflection, *The Carework Project* combines

intimate storytelling with research, interviews, and visual art to explore what care means in a time of climate crisis.

AUGUST 4

The Knave and the Moon



BY RACHEL GILLIG: Aisling Cathedral is in ruins. Three are rumored to be dead—and the king has taken Sybil

Delling as his bride. To show off their union and solidify his power, Benji proposes a series of tournaments throughout the hamlets. Captive and drugged, Sybil remains determined to vanquish him as she once did the Omens, even if she destroys the kingdom's faith—and herself—in the process.

SEPTEMBER 1

Taipei Story | BY R.F. KUANG:



College freshman Lily Chen is off to spend the summer in Taipei, but a promising start quickly unravels. She

feels adrift, a foreigner in a country she thought would feel like home. Then shocking news: Lily's grandfather has passed away. As Lily grieves, she's drawn into a journey of self-discovery—piecing together memories, stories, and silences over a series of hilarious and devastating attempts at connection.

SEPTEMBER 8

Dead Beat | BY LEIGH

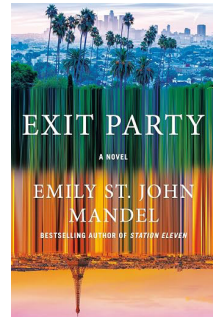


BARDUGO: Alex Stern made it to hell and back more than once, but it's only a matter of time before she faces a

war she cannot win. But for the first time in her life, she won't have to face the fight alone. Dawes, Turner, Mercy, and even Tripp will have a role to play, none more so than Alex's mentor Darlington. Hell itself is stalking the delegates of Lethe House.

SEPTEMBER 14

Exit Party | BY EMILY ST. JOHN

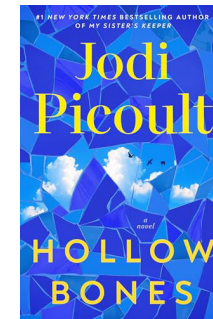


MANDEL: Los Angeles, 2031: The first spring after the collapse of the United States. Ari Waker and her roommate

pass the gauntlet of bomb-sniffing dogs, the shanty towns, and the Red Cross tents as they walk across Silverlake to a party. And then: a shift. A bewildered twin, an uncanny doppelganger, stumbles through the crowd and out into the night, and Kareem, the party's host, vanishes into thin air...

SEPTEMBER 15

Hollow Bones | BY JODI

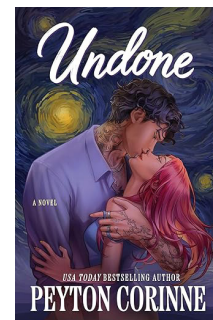


PICOULT: On September 11, 2001, when Molly Fitzgerald's mother went to an appointment at the World

Trade Center and never came home. Moving between past and present, *Hollow Bones* is an epic story of the lies we tell ourselves as we write the narratives of our lives, the plans we design to protect ourselves at the worst moments, and the ties that bind mothers and daughters.

SEPTEMBER 26

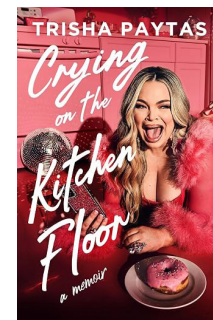
Undone | BY EMMA CORINNE:



After a scandal cost him his first-round NHL draft pick, Toren Kane's last shot at redemption lies with Waterfell University's

hockey team—who all despise him. After flunking out of an Ivy League, Lillian LaBlanc's father's strict rules are the only things keeping her afloat. Her fragile stability is threatened when she discovers that Toren Kane, her childhood best friend and first love, is also attending Waterfell—and is on her father's team. **OCTOBER 20**

Crying on the Kitchen Floor | BY TRISHA PAYTAS:



Like a phoenix, Trisha has risen from the ashes again and again. Across a career marked by both dizzying highs and

earth-shattering lows, one thing has remained unclear: What the hell was she thinking?

NOVEMBER 10

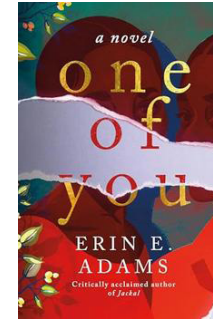
Longtime Listener | BY B.K.



BORISON: A workaholic radio station manager does her best to resist the charms of her corporate enemy in this swoony,

You've Got Mail-inspired romance. **FEBRUARY 2027**

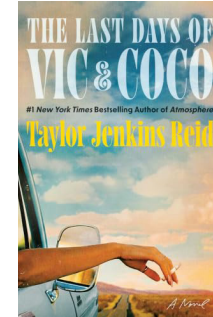
One of You | BY ERIN E. ADAMS:



What would you sacrifice to become American? Everything about the Beauchaire family seems normal—

perfect, even. They immigrated to New York City from Haiti years ago, looking for their own piece of America's promised riches. But beneath this polished exterior, something is just slightly off. There's malice waiting . . . wanting to reveal itself. A mysterious outsider torments two Haitian-American sisters, forcing them to confront dark secrets from their family's past in this powerful psychological suspense novel from the acclaimed author of *Jackal*. **APRIL 2027**

The Last Days of Vic & Coco | BY TAYLOR JENKINS REID:



The con is simple: Coco, magnetic and fearless, draws men in with her good looks and convinces them to play against her

friend, Vic. Precise and unstoppable, Vic runs the table clean. Word is spreading about two women to watch out for, and they're running out of places to hide and marks to hustle. That's when they set in motion a plan that will bring them their biggest payday yet... or cost them everything.

MAY 2027

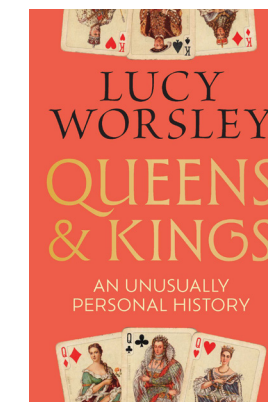
Author Spotlight

LUCY WORSLEY



CRED: Lucy Worsley 2019/LiteraryCritic/CC BY-SA 4.0

Lucy Worsley OBE is Chief Curator at the charity Historic Royal Palaces. She also presents history documentaries for the BBC and PBS. Her bestselling books include *Queen Victoria*; *Jane Austen at Home*; *The Art of the English Murder*; and if *Walls Could Talk: An Intimate History of the Home*. Her next book, *Queens and Kings: An Unusually Personal History of the Monarchy*, releases September 2026. In 2019, her BBC One program *Suffragettes with Lucy Worsley* won a Bafta.



SEPTEMBER 3



ABOVE *The Mother and Sister of the Artist*, 1869, Berthe Morisot, National Gallery

How Austen's Male Leads

in *Pride and Prejudice* and *Persuasion* Aid in Constructing Masculinity in the Nineteenth and Twenty-First Centuries

Avery Morse

While her work is most often talked about in relation to women's experiences, Jane Austen's novels have inspired conversations surrounding men's roles and expectations in society in the early nineteenth century. Specifically, Austen crafts a new ideal for men—an ideal without toxic masculinity or inhibitions from traditional gender stereotypes. While gender expectations have certainly fluctuated for both women and men, Austen's requirements for a good man from over 200 years ago are more relevant now than ever before. Certain qualities Austen's men possess are reflected in today's standards for desirable masculin-

ty. Specifically, *Pride and Prejudice* and *Persuasion* portray the varying degrees of what is considered a non-toxic man in regard to Austen's standards and the standards set forth by modern-day feminism. Whether it be *Pride and Prejudice*'s Mr. Darcy or Mr. Wickham, or *Persuasion*'s Captain Wentworth or Sir Walter, the essential qualities of an acceptable man are depicted at length. What these men do (or fail to do) mirrors twenty-first-century beliefs of how a man should behave in an increasingly equitable world. Whether they expect matrimony or hope for it, are willing to change or are too stubborn, are passionate or reserved, their actions are representative of larg-

er efforts in our society to call attention to how men behave. Through behavior, consent, and proposals, Austen curates the ideal man that transcends her time period and sustains relevance in twenty-first-century ideas of masculinity.

In all of Austen's sketches of the ideal man, something notably missing is rigidity. Traditionally, the ideal man lacks feminine qualities; Austen, however, blurs the line. She does not believe femininity and masculinity are diametrically opposed. Austen rejects the long-held belief that men who show emotion, are sincere, or possess any other qualities deemed feminine are "not manly enough" and therefore not

valuable.

The ideal man in Austen's novels is not some "tough guy" (a persona still admired today). Qualities Austen deems negative are androgynous; they transcend gender boundaries; they are traits neither a man nor a woman should possess. Austen challenges traditional masculinity through her characterization of Captain Wentworth. He is a strong, respected sailor in the military. While his status in society might be questioned at points, not once does a character question his masculinity. This is important when considering that, aside from Anne Elliot and Captain Benwick, Wentworth is one of the most emotional characters in *Persuasion*. "Although he never weeps, Wentworth blushes and blanches as if he were Henry Mackenzie's notorious 'man of feeling,' betraying a keen sensibility that defies the traditional opposition between sentiment and manliness" (Walle 46). Wentworth's emotions are not laughed at; he is still regarded as a successful naval officer. His passion for Anne is seen by viewers as respectable and brave.

Austen further describes this new ideal man through proposals with the culmination of Anne Elliot and Captain Wentworth's engagement in *Persuasion*. Overhearing Anne speak about how

she believes women are those who love the longest, Wentworth decides to write a letter confessing his feelings. He writes,

You pierce my soul. I am half agony, half hope... I offer myself to you again with a heart even more your own than when you almost broke it eight years and a half ago... I have loved none but you... I can hardly write. I am every instant hearing something which overpowers me... A word, a look will be enough to decide whether I enter your father's house this evening, or never (*Persuasion* 225-6).

Thought by some to be Austen's most emotional proposal, it not only reveals the depth of emotion the sailor is capable of, but it allows for Anne's complete autonomy.

Compared to her perceived inevitable engagement with Mr. Elliot—where she was not given a choice in the matter before being the subject of gossip—Wentworth's letter gives Anne physical space, ultimate privacy, and some time to think before she sees him again. Wentworth also allows her “a word, a look” to reject him. This choice of language is especially important when compared to the plethora of words that went ignored by Mr. Collins during his propos-

al to Elizabeth. Wentworth, on the other hand, respects Anne's boundaries to the extent that not even a word is needed; she could only give him a look, and he would respect her decision.

Respecting women's boundaries and choices is exactly the behavior Austen's successful proposals embody. Darcy's second and final proposal is a textbook example of the ideal Austenian man: “You are too generous to

should she say no. He makes it clear that Elizabeth is under no obligation to consider him seriously after how he has behaved. He says, “By you, I was properly humbled. You showed me how insufficient were all my pretensions to please a woman worthy of being pleased” (*Pride and Prejudice* 349). Reformed behavior deconstructs preconceived notions of masculinity. Someone seen as a traditional man would like-

ly be portrayed as unchanging, correct in every matter, and not to be challenged by women. Darcy, however, takes Elizabeth's criticism in stride, showcasing that the ideal man is capable

of change.

Austen is taught around the world to men who can stand to benefit from the standards she redefined in the nineteenth century. Devoney Looser shared her experience doing just that in her article, “Teaching Jane Austen to sex offenders,” where she details her time leading a class on the author's novels at Florence State Prison. Looser had positive experiences with her male students in the prison and was left hoping that “they might talk about fe-

male-centered stories that model independence, that prompt questions about consent and self-control” (Looser). Because Looser used Austen's male characters to model good behavior to modern men, it's clear that Austen's novels continue to fit the standard of ideal male behavior and hold relevance for teaching men that change is possible over 200 years after their publication.

Another way that Austen positions male characters is the help they can provide for their female counterparts. In contrast with Mr. Elliot's refusal to care for Mrs. Smith, Wentworth takes the woman's financial problems and solves them. He recovers “her husband's property in the West Indies; by writing for her, acting for her, and seeing her through all the petty difficulties of the case,” and thereby proves that a man of honor is one who uses his power in society to improve the lives of women, who have no power over their situation. Anne, admitting that Mrs. Smith is among the few people she cares about, notes how Wentworth had “the activity and exertion of a fearless man and a determined friend” in helping Mrs. Smith (*Persuasion* 239). The two words, “fearless man” and “determined friend,” seem juxtaposed when considering traditional male stereotypes, but Austen combines

them in Wentworth to show a new masculinity. This masculinity finds men capable of being fearless, strong military men who are also capable of showing emotion, genuine friendship, and helping out those less fortunate than themselves.

All of these traits—the ability to show emotion, change, show vulnerability, respect boundaries, etc.—are more essential now than ever. With our culture redefining what it means to be a man and holding masculinity to higher standards, Austen's reformed masculinity shows us that men are capable of change. In establishing how a good man should behave, along with how he shouldn't, Austen redefines masculinity by nineteenth-century standards. The behavior of her male characters informs everyone about the negative behaviors that men can portray. This behavior can be seen in the twenty-first century, with men being faced with consequences like loneliness if they don't adopt the emotions of Wentworth or Darcy's desire to change. *Pride and Prejudice* and *Persuasion* offer readers essential standards to inform their own beliefs on what constitutes non-toxic masculinity. These standards are what guide us, over two centuries after Darcy proposed to Eliz-

abeth, in rejecting the men who fail to respect consent or boundaries. Through the behavior of her characters and their notions of consent that guide their proposals, Austen crafts a new masculinity that guides us in the twenty-first century.



AVERY MORSE

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Autofiction

A Blur Between the Real and Unreal

Katy Burch

As writers, we write ourselves and our reality into our work, whether that be fiction or nonfiction, intentionally or unintentionally. Autofiction allows us to blur this line further, questioning our own realities and allowing our minds to wander into what could have been. William Lychack does a hauntingly beautiful job of this in his book, *Cargill Falls*. Autofiction is a style of writing that mixes fact and fiction to uncover an

emotional truth for the writer and reader. However, I believe that autofiction can really only be claimed by the writer themselves.

To understand how a book qualifies as autofiction, you have to understand the author, their past, and their intentions. Without knowing the history of a piece, you have no knowledge of what is real or what is fictionalized unless it is explicitly stated or claimed by the author; that's why we as readers cannot qualify a piece as autofiction unless we have prior, intimate knowledge of the author's intentions. Specifically, when we look at *Cargill Falls*, we may automatically assume it's creative nonfiction because Lychack uses his own name for the main character. The

name would suggest he is telling his "real" life story, but classifying it as a novel on the front cover argues against this assertion. Although he himself does not use the word, the

juxtaposition of Lychack's pronouncement that his work is fiction, while infusing his name, history, and characteristics into the main character is, in a subtle way, the author claiming autofiction.

After researching past interviews and becoming privy to a Zoom call with the author during a creative writing course, I learned Lychack's original intentions, which definitively qualify *Cargill Falls* as autofiction. During the call, Lychack explained that writing wasn't about changing the past but rather a way of looking for truth. The death of his friend—Brownie, as he is named in the story—is real. The gun (arguably the driving force behind the piece) is completely fictional. The creation of the gun was a literary move on Lychack's part to uncover

an emotional truth for himself: a shift in their lives that drove the two boys apart and sealed Brownie's fate. There was no shift, no gun, that Lychack could pull from his real life, so he imagined one to create an understanding for himself.

Lychack blurs the line between the real and unreal in the first line of his novel. It begins, "We once found a gun in the woods—true story—me and Brownie..." and goes on to explain the encounter in excruciating detail. As a reader, when you see the words "true story" in the first line and believe the author is the main character, you are inclined to see the writing as nonfiction. However, that assumption is decidedly not true. Lychack doesn't break any

contract with the reader because he, again, titled *Cargill Falls* as a novel, and, therefore, did not promise complete accuracy. However, he does put the reader in a state of confusion, searching for truth in untruth. This is the purpose of the novel,

not a flaw; Lychack is searching for the truth, too! After revealing that the adult version of the narrator is dealing with the aftermath of Brownie's suicide, Lychack writes that he is "a ghost sifting for something solid in the ashes" (20). The character Mouse searches for what could have gone differently so he and Brownie wouldn't end up in this situation. The real Lychack does the same by writing it. It is not the author's duty to reveal what is real or unreal, as long as both are present, and readers are not meant to interpret which is which. Autofiction is what the writer makes it to be, as we search for an emotional truth together.

It is not the author's duty to reveal what is real or unreal, as long as both are present

RIGHT *Child in a Straw Hat*, 1886, Mary Cassatt, National Gallery



Dear Reader, Katy Burch

I don't trust myself to be a writer. I've been writing my whole life, but it wasn't even until last year I actually started using the term. I didn't believe I deserved it.

I'd write for class. I'd write for fun. I'd write in my notes app when inspiration struck (usually during traumatic moments). I'd scribble poetry in notebooks and ask for my friends' opinions. In my mind, none of this made me a writer. Looking back, that doesn't even make sense.

Writing doesn't make you a writer. That's not how that works, though.

Once I get published, I'll be a real writer. Again, not how that works.

Everybody who has ever complimented your writing is lying. Wow. Everyone, huh? Impressive.

Teachers give good grades because you're an average kid who understands good grammar—nothing special. Professors don't write "It'd be a shame if you don't major in Creative Writing" on an essay because you "understand grammar."

Your friends compliment you because friends support friends, a.k.a friends lie to save your feelings. When have they ever held back criticism? Never, that's the answer. You're a good writer, and those jeans don't flatter your ass. Accept it.

I've never been able to believe that I was worthy of praise, that I worked for it, that I've earned it. I've sold myself short so no one else could. But if I can't see my own potential, who's going to look hard enough to notice? No one else is going to call me a writer if I'm too scared to say the word myself.

"So," I say, "I'm a writer." My voice shakes, uncertain. Saying it out loud makes it real.

You're not a writer. "Yes, I am."

It takes a few times, but my voice steadies, and I start to believe myself. Believe in myself. If you write, you're a writer. If you've ever written or plan to write, you're a writer. I am a writer, even though I struggle. Even though I go months without typing a word, a blank Google Doc staring back at me.

You're not a writer! it screams. I waver.

But when I step back into reality and stop personifying that Google Doc, I realize no one is questioning me besides myself. If I say I'm a writer, everyone believes I am a writer. They don't demand a polished manuscript on their desk by noon. There is no qualification I have to meet, no bank statement I have to present as proof that my words are worth something. My refusal to write, merely be-

cause I don't think I've "earned it," is the only thing standing in between me and, well, writing.

I am and always have been a real writer. I move people with my words because I have skill, and I have skill because I believe in myself. I see myself. When in doubt, I say it out loud for everyone to hear—especially me.

Love,

A Writer



KATY BURCH

is a library associate currently pursuing her MFA in Creative Writing at the University of Monticello. With an emphasis in creative nonfiction, she is currently working on an essay collection that traces her parents' lives through the aging of their bodies and reckons with how their pain has shaped her own. Her works have been published in the *Vortex Magazine of Literature and Fine Art*. She currently resides in her South Arkansas hometown with her husband, father, and perfectly spoiled dog.



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